



R. V. MOORTHY

the normal period for the league is between September and March.

What is the update on including PIO/OCI players in the national team? Can you share the names of the 33 shortlisted players?

Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) and Person of Indian Origin (PIO) cardholders are foreign nationals granted limited social and economic rights in India. However, since India does not recognise dual citizenship,

these cards do not confer Indian nationality.

Cardholders often have strong ancestral ties to India — through parents, grandparents, or prior residence — which can influence sporting eligibility and, in some cases, allow for national representation.

We are exploring how PIO/OCI players can align with FIFA statutes, Indian citizenship laws, and the national sports policy.

This is an ongoing process, and

until we receive clarity from FIFA and the Government of India, we cannot disclose any names.

What are AIFF's plans for the Indian Women's League (IWL)?

The IWL is growing, with expanded participation, the launch of IWL 2, and initiatives like Asmita. Our goal is to widen the talent pool and strengthen the ecosystem.

Many ISL players underperform at the national level despite high salaries from their clubs. Is AIFF considering salary caps?

Player salaries are contracts between clubs and individuals. The AIFF cannot intervene in these matters.

The Supreme Court verdict on the AIFF constitution is due on July 18. How will the AIFF respond?

The Supreme Court is the highest authority in our country. The AIFF will fully abide by any judgment it delivers.

Several clubs have opted out of the Durand Cup. What is AIFF's roadmap for this tournament? And what's the status of the Federation Cup? Will it replace the Super Cup?

The Durand Cup is organised independently by the Indian Army. AIFF will continue to support it with technical assistance and a tournament slot.

The Super Cup continues as planned, and its scheduling will depend on the finalised league (ISL) calendar.

What did you take away from your recent meeting with Arsene Wenger?

I learned about a new FIFA 8v8 Under-15 competition to be played on half-sized pitches, designed to improve ball control and build-up play. India will participate in this initiative.

Mr. Wenger also stressed that beginning football at 13 is too late — players should start by age eight. In India, most children begin around 12–13. Through the Golden Baby League and Blue Cubs, we are trying